



BurNer Kings

We've always encouraged you to buy the best, not what the dealer dishes out. So which one *is* the best? Here's our 2007 test for optical drives

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With the increasing penetration of broadband in Indian households, we've begun downloading more and more and before long, find that there's no space left on our hard drive(s). What does one do when one wants to download more? Apart from this, there's the question of backups. In both cases, optical media is the answer.

Optical drives are fairly common these days, and there is scarcely a computer today without one. An optical drive is a CD, DVD, Blu-ray, or HD-DVD drive in most cases. Of these, CD and DVD-Writers are easily available and at throwaway prices—some as low as Rs 2,000.

A year has passed since our last DVD-Writer shootout. Not much has changed since—there have only been a few minor improvements in technology. The speeds of DVD-Writers have been upped a notch or two to 18x and even 20x, though such drives are only just beginning to appear in the market (and we got a few of these too).

This time round, we not only tested DVD-Writers, but also Combo drives: they are still popular because they are priced between Rs 500 to 1,000 lower than DVD-Writers.

We received a total of 12 drives: eight DVD-Writers and four Combo drives, from five brands.

COMBO DRIVES

Combo drives are CD-Writers that can also read DVDs. The popularity of such drives rose steeply here in India when *Digit* started bundling free DVDs full of goodies around two and a half years ago.

Today, combo drives are usually bundled with most PCs, and are usually preferred by the budget-sensitive consumer.

Already on the decline, we received only four products in this category from four brands: the LG GCC-H21N, Lite-On SOHC-5232K, Sony CRX320EE, and the Samsung OctoEdge SH-522C.